

Deliverable 2: Proposal Presentation & Write-Up

Web Archive Forensics for Independent Accountability Journalists in North Carolina

A Reference and Capture Service Proposal for the State Library of North Carolina

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Introduction

In April 2026, USA Today published an investigation that reconstructed how U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) had quietly altered its public detention statistics over time. The reporters could only do this because the Internet Archive's Wayback Machine had preserved the earlier versions of ICE's pages before the agency changed them. There is, as Wayback Machine director Mark Graham noted in Wired, "a little irony" in this. USA Today Co., the publishing conglomerate formerly known as Gannett and operator of more than 200 outlets nationwide, actively bars the Wayback Machine from archiving its own work (Knibbs, 2026). The story illustrates exactly what the Wayback Machine exists to do, and exactly how fragile that capacity has become.

This proposal addresses a specific NC population for whom that fragility is not an abstraction but an immediate threat to daily work: independent and freelance accountability journalists in counties classified as news deserts or watch counties by the Medill State of Local News Project (Medill Local News Initiative, 2025).). For these reporters (contributors to Carolina Public Press and NC Newsline, hyperlocal newsletter operators, and freelance investigative journalists without institutional newsroom infrastructure), the Wayback Machine is not one tool among many. It is the backbone of source preservation, editorial-change tracking, and evidentiary documentation. As publishers withdraw access and the Internet Archive faces simultaneous pressure from AI scraping, copyright-driven blocking, and cyberattacks (Knibbs, 2026; Sircar, 2026; Kennedy, 2026), the question for these journalists is no longer whether their primary verification tool will fail. It is when, and whether anything institutional will be there to replace it.

The proposal argues that the State Library of North Carolina (SLNC), in partnership with the State Archives of North Carolina, is uniquely positioned to provide an institutional alternative at the state level. Drawing on Koufogiannakis's (2013) evidence-based library and information practice (EBLIP) framework, it assembles both "hard" evidence (peer-reviewed research on journalist information behavior, Medill longitudinal news-desert data, web-archiving practice studies) and "soft" evidence (working journalists' accounts of their verification practices, NC nonprofit-newsroom case profiles, professional infrastructure observations). It argues for a three-part service at the State Library of North Carolina (SLNC), in partnership with the State Archives of North Carolina: (1) a capture-on-demand reference service for credentialed NC journalists; (2) a quarterly hybrid workshop series on web archive forensics, delivered statewide through the NC Cardinal consortium; and (3) a curated NC Accountability Web Collection in Archive-It, extending SLNC's existing web archiving program to public-interest sources beyond state government.

Search Methodology

The literature review proceeded through four concurrent streams documented in the order they were conducted. First, academic-database searches via UNC Libraries (Google Scholar, EBSCO Communication & Mass Media Complete, JSTOR, LISA) on journalism verification practices, freelance journalism information behavior, library-newsroom partnerships, web archiving practices in libraries and archives, and information source horizons. Second, current-events monitoring on the April 2026 Internet Archive crisis cluster across *Wired*, *Forbes*, *Nieman Reports*, *Library Journal*, and PCMag. Third, institutional documentation review across the State Library of NC, the State Archives of NC, the NC Cardinal consortium, the Government Records Section's G.S. 132 Files records-management blog, the NC

Website and Social Media Archives, the State Archives Discover Online Catalog, the NC Digital Heritage Center, the Library of NC's Data and Evaluation services, the Library of Congress's Web Archiving Program, the UNC Hussman Center for Innovation and Sustainability in Local Media (CISLM), NC Local, and the Coastal Journalism Hub. This stream confirmed the institutional landscape claim: NC has active workshop infrastructure, an Archive-It web archiving program, a digitization service hub, and an emerging collaborative-journalism ecosystem, but no current programming for journalist-facing web-archive-forensics reference, instruction, or curation. Fourth, snowball citation chasing extended each stream to foundational LIS information-behavior frameworks (Bates, 1989; Savolainen, 2008; Sonnenwald, 1999; Taylor, 1991; Koufogiannakis, 2013), to peer-reviewed studies of web archiving practice (Pennock, 2013; Wong & Chiu, 2024; Vlassenroot, Tao, & Mechant, 2025; Zannettou et al., 2018), to library-newsroom precedent cases (LeBeau, 2018; Carlson, 2019; Cifu, 2023; Pohl, 2025; Peet, 2018), and to the legal-citation analog of journalistic source verification (Zittrain, Albert, & Lessig, 2013).

The User Population: NC's Independent Accountability Journalists

This proposal targets working accountability journalists in North Carolina who (a) cover civic, governmental, or institutional accountability beats, (b) operate without the staff infrastructure of a major daily newsroom, and (c) work in or cover NC counties classified as news deserts or watch counties in the most recent Medill State of Local News Report (Medill Local News Initiative, 2025). The population includes freelance contributors and full-time reporters at Carolina Public Press, an Asheville-based nonprofit founded in 2011 that now produces statewide investigative reporting with a small full-time staff and approximately ten freelance writers (CISLM, 2020; Carolina Public Press, n.d.); reporters at NC Newsline, the nonpartisan nonprofit founded in 2004 as NC Policy Watch and renamed in 2023 (NC Newsline, n.d.); hyperlocal newsletter operators; civic Substack writers covering county-level government; and freelance contributors to legacy NC outlets whose newsrooms have shrunk or vanished.

Taylor's (1991) concept of an *information use environment* (IUE) frames this population well. Taylor characterized IUEs by the people involved, the problems they encounter, the settings in which those problems arise, and what counts as a resolution. Where Taylor profiled engineers, legislators, and physicians, NC's independent accountability journalists form a recognizable IUE of their own. The people are defined by professional training and beat assignment. The problems organize around editorial-change verification, source preservation, and evidentiary documentation. The setting is remote and freelance work, irregular hours, minimal institutional infrastructure. The resolution is both the published story and a defensible record of what was true at publication.

Structural conditions for this IUE have worsened sharply. The Medill Local News Initiative's State of Local News Report 2025 found that 213 U.S. counties now have no local news source at all, with another 1,524 counties served by only one outlet. Approximately 50 million Americans live with limited or no access to local news, and almost 80% of news desert counties are classified by the USDA as predominantly rural (Culpepper, 2025; Medill Local News Initiative, 2025). North Carolina's situation is among the most acute in the country. UNC Hussman School of Journalism and Media's Center for Innovation and Sustainability in Local Media documented that as of 2019, six NC counties had no newspapers at all and 58 had only one (Community News Center, 2024). , which goes beyond newspaper headquarters to map actual coverage access, identified 378 news media outlets serving NC communities statewide, with eastern NC counties receiving the least coverage and access (CISLM, 2023). CISLM's *Stayers and Leavers* and *Local News Burnout* surveys of more than 1,000 current and former local journalists document that those who remain do so motivated by community service but face structurally unsustainable pay, limited work-life balance, and high burnout rates (CISLM, 2023, 2024). Where local newspapers once absorbed the cost of accountability reporting, that work has shifted to freelance and nonprofit-affiliated journalists with fewer resources, working under measurably difficult conditions. CISLM's *Stayers and Leavers* survey of more than 600 current and former local journalists found that those who remain in the field do so motivated by community service but face structural obstacles to long-term career sustainability, including unsustainable pay and limited work-life balance (CISLM, 2024). CISLM's earlier *Local News Burnout* survey of more than 500 local journalists found that burnout and intent-to-leave run high among working local reporters (CISLM, 2023). Comparative international research on freelance journalism documents three durable barriers that distinguish this population from staff reporters at major dailies: limited time for verification work, restricted access to subscription databases and institutional research support, and minimal institutional infrastructure for legal-evidentiary documentation of source pages (Bossio, O'Donnell, & Lugo-Ocando, 2023). These reporters' commitment to professional journalistic norms is shaped less by employment structure than by training and identity. They practice journalism at the same standard as staff counterparts, with significantly less infrastructure to support them.

Practicing Verification and Why the Wayback Machine Matters

Verification is not peripheral to journalism. In Kovach and Rosenstiel's formulation, it is "the discipline of journalism" itself, the activity that distinguishes journalism from other forms of communication (Kovach & Rosenstiel, 2014). Shapiro, Brin, Bédard-Brûlé, and Mychajlowycz (2013) conducted the first empirical study of how journalists actually verify. Through post-hoc qualitative

interviews with 28 semi-randomly selected Canadian journalists, who each reconstructed verification work for a single published story, they found that journalists treat verification as a “strategic ritual” central to professional identity. Their interviewees described verification practices that closely mirrored social-scientific methods: source triangulation, analysis of primary documents, semi-participant observation. The CUNY Newmark Graduate School of Journalism’s fact-checking research guides now teach Shapiro et al.’s framing alongside Kovach and Rosenstiel as the foundational account of what verification is and why it matters (CUNY Newmark, n.d.).

Shapiro et al. (2013) document what skilled verification looks like, but their study assumes the institutional infrastructure that enables it. Their participants worked at staff newspapers with research support, archive access, and editorial review. The findings therefore describe verification practices without addressing who has access to the conditions that make those practices possible. That gap is what this proposal addresses: extending the infrastructural conditions for skilled verification to journalists who currently lack them.

Verification, in practice, looks much like what Bates (1989) called berrypicking: iterative information seeking through multiple, mutually reinforcing techniques rather than a single query against a single database. The techniques Bates identified map cleanly onto accountability reporting. Footnote chasing means following primary sources cited in published reporting. Citation searching means finding later references to a known document. Journal run means scanning all available versions of a single source over time. Area scanning means browsing related coverage. For an accountability reporter tracking a county commissioner’s shifting public statements, footnote chasing might mean tracing a quoted statistic back to the original agency report. Journal run might mean reviewing every Wayback Machine snapshot of the commissioner’s campaign website over a six-month window. Area scanning might mean browsing related local-government pages for similar patterns. Bates’ model captures the iterative, multi-source character of journalistic verification better than the single-query model that dominated early information-retrieval research.

Where do journalists place these techniques on what Savolainen (2008) and Sonnenwald (1999) call their *information source horizons*, the field of preferred-to-disfavored sources from which a person draws when resolving an information need? For NC’s independent accountability journalists, the closest sources are typically Google search, social media, cultivated sources and contacts, public records portals, and the Wayback Machine. Subscription databases (LexisNexis, Factiva, ProQuest Historical Newspapers) sit far away, not because journalists undervalue them but because access is paywalled and institutionally restricted. The Wayback Machine’s position close to the journalist is not incidental. It is free, immediately responsive, and the only publicly available tool that supports journal-run analysis of archived web content.

Kate Knibbs's *Wired* investigation describes the routine uses. Journalists track editorial changes, as in the 2016 case where *The New York Times* quietly revised a Bernie Sanders article during the presidential primary, traceable only because the Archive had preserved the original. They pull archived pages as forensic evidence in litigation, documenting how employers and institutions have changed their public-facing positions over time (Knibbs, 2026). Chicago Reader journalist Micco Caporale, profiled in the same article, used the Wayback Machine to track historical job listings and pay fluctuations in union-organizing reporting--a use case impossible to reproduce through any other publicly available tool. The *USA Today* ICE-statistics investigation cited at the opening of this proposal is itself a case in point. None of these workflows can run through subscription databases that independent journalists cannot access (Cabrera, 2025). April Hines, journalism and mass communications librarian at the University of Florida, described the gap to the National Press Club Journalism Institute: well-resourced reporters work through institutional libraries, while freelancers and small-newsroom journalists rely on local public library subscriptions and whatever is freely available online (Cabrera, 2025). For a freelance reporter in a rural NC county, the Wayback Machine is the very forensic-archive infrastructure of their reporting.

Threat Context: Disrupted Information Behavior

When Hurricane Helene devastated Western North Carolina in October 2024, local journalists worked through power outages, washed-out roads, and rapidly shifting state and federal information to cover the disaster and its recovery. CISLM's *In the Eye of the Storm* study of local news coverage of Helene found that local outlets played essential roles in distributing emergency information, tracking disaster response, and holding agencies accountable for recovery decisions (CISLM, 2025). The reporting work CISLM documents depends, then and now, on tools that capture and preserve agency communications as those communications change. Many of those communications were issued through state agency social media accounts and county government websites that are not systematically archived for journalistic verification use. The Helene case shows in concentrated form what is true more generally: NC accountability journalism in moments of crisis depends on infrastructure no one has built for it.

The Internet Archive, the Library of Congress's web archiving programs, and similar digital institutions preserve the web because the web does not preserve itself. Pages disappear, URLs break, publishers revise stories, agencies remove pages, companies shut down sites, and platforms change access rules. Pew research found that a quarter of webpages that existed at some point between 2013 and 2023 were inaccessible by October 2023, and 38 percent of 2013 webpages were unavailable a decade later (Pew Research Center, 2024). Operating on a simple democratic premise that the open web should remain open for the future, these institutions work to preserve the record of the open web so that journalists,

researchers, educators, courts, and future generations can know what was said, changed, deleted, or hidden. Web archives make it possible to investigate government revisions, track changes in news reporting, recover dead links, preserve community history, and resist the quiet disappearance of digital culture.

Nowadays, AI companies need enormous volumes of text, images, metadata, and historical material. Digital archives are attractive because they contain structured, time-stamped, high-value materials at scale: public domain books, OCR files, news pages, government documents, web snapshots, and records that may no longer exist on the live web. The same architecture that makes these archives valuable for preservation also makes them vulnerable to extraction.

For instance, the Internet Archive is the largest digital preservation nonprofit in the world, holding over a trillion captured webpages. Journalists use it to track editorial changes; litigants submit archived pages as evidence; historians study how political language has shifted. On Memorial Day weekend in 2023, as the Archive's founder and director Brewster Kahle documented in a public blog post, tens of thousands of requests per second for OCR text files arrived from sixty-four coordinated virtual hosts on Amazon Web Services, crashing the Archive for roughly an hour (Kahle, 2023). Upon blocking those IP addresses, in just a few hours another sixty-four resumed the same behavior. In October 2024, the Archive sustained a long Blackmeta DDoS (denial-of-service) attack that knocked it offline for weeks (Richard, 2024). Such incidents revealed that the Archive's infrastructure, designed for public access, is unequipped to negotiate terms with an extractive industry operating at machine scale. An open archive can be treated as a free input pipeline by commercial actors who do not bear the costs of preservation.

In April 2026, three trade publications and *Wired* published nearly simultaneous investigations of an accelerating crisis at the Internet Archive (Knibbs, 2026; Sircar, 2026; Kennedy, 2026). 241 news sites from nine countries now explicitly disallow at least one of the Internet Archive's four crawling bots through robots.txt. 87 percent of those sites are owned by USA Today Co., which operates more than 200 media outlets. *The New York Times* employs hard-blocking measures beyond standard robots.txt conventions. *The Guardian* excludes its journalism content from the Wayback Machine interface while permitting only regional and topic pages. Reddit blocked the Archive's access to post detail pages, user comments, and profiles in August 2025, citing AI-company use of the Archive as a backdoor to content Reddit was licensing to Google for \$60 million per year (Joseph, 2025).

The structural problem behind it has three parts. First, AI training is effectively irreversible. Once a model has incorporated text into its weights, no one can extract that influence on demand. The UVA Archival AI Protocol takes this fact as its foundation, applying what it calls a principle of reversibility:

archivists do not do what cannot be undone. Second, the Archive's own infrastructure invites the very behavior that hurts it. The public Scraping API at archive.org/services/search/v1/scrape provides cursor-based bulk access with no commercial restrictions, and commercial scraping vendors openly market the Archive as a target. Automatio advertises "Intelligent Retry Logic" as a feature for getting around the Archive's rate limits. The open-source Wayback Machine Scraper on GitHub provides configurable concurrency settings explicitly for scraping historical snapshots at scale. Third, the publishers most affected by AI training have begun blocking the Archive's preservation crawlers as their only available defense.

The downstream consequences are now playing out. Zannettou and colleagues' (2018) study of archive use across Reddit, Twitter, Gab, and 4chan found that automated moderation bots account for 44% of archive.is URLs and 85% of Wayback Machine URLs shared on Reddit, with substantial volumes used to redirect readers away from original news sources. The authors estimate that the Washington Post alone loses approximately \$70,000 annually in Reddit-driven ad revenue through this practice (Zannettou et al., 2018). The Electronic Frontier Foundation's Joe Mullin compared publisher blocking of the Internet Archive to "a newspaper publisher announcing it will no longer allow libraries to keep copies of its paper," warning that "sacrificing the public record to fight those battles would be a profound, and possibly irreversible, mistake" (cited in Kennedy, 2026). More than 100 working journalists, including Rachel Maddow, Taylor Lorenz, and Kat Tenbarger, signed a letter organized by EFF, Fight for the Future, and Public Knowledge describing the Archive as the institutional successor to physical newspaper morgues and public library clipping files. "With many newspapers closed, and no clear path for local public libraries to preserve digital-only reporting, the work of safeguarding journalism's record increasingly falls to the Internet Archive" (cited in Knibbs, 2026).

The asymmetric burden falls on independent journalists. A *New York Times* or *Washington Post* reporter blocked from the Wayback Machine still has institutional research staff, in-house archives going back decades, and subscription-database access to LexisNexis or ProQuest Historical Newspapers. A freelance reporter at Carolina Public Press, or a Substack journalist covering county commissioner meetings in eastern NC, has none of those things. For them, the Wayback Machine's fragility is the fragility of their entire forensic-research workflow, and a major disruption to their information source horizon.

Setting: The State Library of North Carolina's Existing Capacity

The State Library of North Carolina is the right institutional home for this service for four reasons. First, SLNC and the State Archives of North Carolina already operate the North Carolina State Government Web Site Archives and Access Program, an established web archiving service launched in 2005 under statutory mandates from G.S. 121-2, G.S. 125-11.5–11.13, and G.S. 132-1b (State Archives of North Carolina & State Library of North Carolina, n.d.). The program holds approximately 24.3 TB of archived web content as of January 2020 (Digital Commons NC, 2020). SLNC therefore already has the technical and curatorial infrastructure the proposed service requires, such as Archive-It and ArchiveSocial accounts, staff trained in web-archive curation and quality control, and metadata and access infrastructure that makes captured content discoverable.

Second, SLNC's Government and Heritage Library has a statutory mission to serve all NC residents, not only those with institutional library affiliation. Independent journalists are exactly the kind of user SLNC was built to reach. Third, SLNC's statewide remit through the NC Cardinal consortium of partner public libraries provides a delivery channel no other NC institution possesses. Workshops and instructional programming developed centrally at SLNC can reach reporters in news desert counties through partner public libraries, with no travel to Raleigh required. Fourth, SLNC's existing partnership with the North Carolina Digital Heritage Center provides a model for cross-institutional NC preservation coordination and a potential governance structure for curation decisions in the proposed Accountability Web Collection.

The existing State Government Web Site Archives program is scoped to NC state agency websites and social media (State Archives of NC & State Library of NC, n.d.). It does not cover non-governmental public-interest sources. SLNC's existing workshop infrastructure, run through the Government Records Section's G.S. 132 Files blog, delivers records-management training to government employees on retention schedules, disposition, and electronic records management (Leonard, 2026). It does not cover web archive forensics, archive-based source verification, or capture-on-demand reference for working journalists. The Government Records Section serves the creators and custodians of NC public records; no NC institution currently serves the researchers, verifiers, and accountability investigators who use those records. The proposed service extends SLNC's existing infrastructure into adjacent territory rather than duplicating it, addressing this complementary gap.

Library-Newsroom Service Precedents

This proposal is not the first to recognize that public libraries have natural complementarity with accountability journalism, but it is the first known proposal to combine capture-on-demand web-archive reference, journalist-focused archive-forensics instruction, and curated public-interest web preservation under a single state-library service designed for independent accountability journalists. A small but growing literature documents how libraries and newsrooms can work together.

Christopher LeBeau's 2018 *Reference & User Services Quarterly* (RUSQ) piece, written from his vantage as then-president of RUSA, frames libraries' reference services as a natural extension into supporting local journalism amid newsroom collapse. The piece builds on a 2011 "Beyond Books: News, Literacy, Democracy, and America's Libraries" conference that brought librarians and journalists into structured dialogue (LeBeau, 2018). More recent practice-based reporting in *Library Journal* documents the Cleveland Public Library's space-sharing agreement with Signal, a community news outlet that trains "documenters" to attend public meetings and produce notes. Signal journalists use library buildings to work, research, and recruit documenters (Pohl, 2025). The Albany Public Library partnered with the Times Union on a multi-month series investigating the city's Pearl Street, with the library and the newspaper jointly surveying readers and co-producing articles (Cifu, 2023).

The Dallas Public Library's Storytellers Without Borders program, profiled by Eryn Carlson in *Nieman Reports*, trains high school journalists to use library archives, including back copies of The Dallas Morning News, as research infrastructure for local reporting (Carlson, 2019). Storytellers Without Borders is a useful precedent here even though its participants are not the working independent journalists this proposal targets. It demonstrates that the workshop tier of the proposed service is feasible at a public library, and that the population concept extends naturally to journalism education contexts. If SLNC chose to expand the workshop tier to include journalism students at NC universities (UNC Hussman, NC State, NC A&T, and North Carolina Central), Storytellers Without Borders provides a direct implementation model.

Perhaps the closest existing precedent for the curatorial component of this proposal is the Black Hills Knowledge Network at Rapid City Public Library, where digital and special collections librarian Samantha Slocum coordinates a public-facing online resource that organizes scattered information (academic articles, government reports, news accounts) into curated "issue hubs" on regional topics of public interest (Peet, 2018). The Black Hills model demonstrates that public libraries can sustainably curate ongoing topical web resources for civic information needs, and that doing so reinforces rather than displaces traditional reference services.

None of these precedents focuses specifically on web archive forensics, capture-on-demand reference, or evidentiary preservation of public-interest sources. None has been implemented in North Carolina or for the specific population of independent accountability journalists in NC news deserts. While capture-on-demand services exist at the Library of Congress and through Perma.cc for legal-citation contexts, no institution has implemented this service for working independent journalists in any state, and no NC institution has built any of these three tiers for this population.

North Carolina has a growing collaborative-journalism infrastructure that this service complements rather than competes with. NC Local, the nonprofit successor to the NC Local News Workshop, runs a Statewide Newsroom producing original reporting, a Partnership Network distributing free content to NC newsrooms, and statewide community listening events (NC Local, n.d.). The Coastal Journalism Hub connects coastal NC newsrooms, arts institutions, and civic organizations around shared health-focused reporting (Coastal Journalism Hub, n.d.). UNC Hussman's CISLM has run five annual Local Journalism Researchers Workshops, coordinated a statewide NC Diversity Audit, and recently piloted chatbot deployments at four NC newsrooms through its Local NewsBot Studio (CISLM, 2025). None of this existing ecosystem addresses archival preservation, source-verification capacity, or evidentiary capture infrastructure. The proposed SLNC service fills that gap and would coordinate with NC Local, the Coastal Journalism Hub, and CISLM as natural partners on credentialing, training delivery, and outreach.

The Information Need

The population of NC independent accountability journalists has a documented and currently unmet information need: capturing, authenticating, and preserving public-facing web content of accountability significance, in a manner that survives the source's subsequent modification, deletion, or removal from the Wayback Machine. The Internet Archive currently meets this need partially and fragiley. As that infrastructure becomes more contested, the need is becoming unmet.

The need has three components, each mapping to a tier of the proposed service. The first is real-time capture: producing an authenticated, timestamped capture of any web source encountered during reporting, one that will persist regardless of what the source publisher subsequently does. The legal community has documented this need rigorously in adjacent contexts. Zittrain, Albert, and Lessig (2013) found that more than 70% of URLs cited in Harvard Law Review articles and 50% of URLs cited in U.S. Supreme Court opinions no longer resolve to their original content, a phenomenon they call "reference rot." Their proposed solution, the Perma.cc system, asks libraries to preserve link contents as a distributed

long-term archival service. Journalistic source verification faces the same structural problem and would benefit from the same institutional response. The second component of the information need is instructional capacity: the skills to use existing capture tools (the Wayback Machine’s “Save Page Now” feature, ArchiveBox, the Library of Congress’s public web archive, Conifer) effectively, to authenticate captured pages for evidentiary use, and to interpret historical archive snapshots forensically by detecting editorial changes between snapshots through journal-run comparison. The third is institutional preservation: a state-level archival hedge against the possibility that public-interest NC web content captured by the Internet Archive becomes unavailable through publisher action, technical failure, or sustained attack on the Archive itself.

Koufogiannakis’s (2013) framework for evidence-based library and information practice provides the orienting model. Her revised five-stage model (*articulate, assemble, assess, agree, adapt*) explicitly accounts for both group decision-making (a feature of how SLNC actually operates) and the integration of “hard” and “soft” evidence types. The articulate stage of this proposal identifies the problem: the disruption of an essential information practice for an underserved professional population. The assemble stage gathers research evidence (Shapiro et al., 2013; Bossio et al., 2023; Medill, 2025), local data (CISLM’s NC News & Information Census; SLNC’s existing Archive-It capacity), professional commentary (the EFF letter; the Caporale union-organizing example), and precedent cases (Black Hills Knowledge Network, Storytellers Without Borders, Cleveland’s Signal partnership). The proposal that follows reflects the assess stage. The agree, implementation, and adapt stages are the work of SLNC and its partners if the proposal moves forward. Bonn, Bolick, and Cross’s (2023) framework of “Access as Praxis” principle runs through the proposal as a whole: access is not a passive value but an active institutional commitment that must adapt as the infrastructure of access changes.

A Multi-Tiered Service Proposal

The proposed service operates in three tiers, each addressing one of the components of the information need identified above. The tiers are scalable to SLNC’s available resources, designed so that any one can be implemented independently, but together they produce reinforcing benefits. The proposal as a whole assumes phased implementation over a roughly two-year horizon.

Tier 1: Capture-on-Demand Reference Service

SLNC would establish a credentialed service through which qualifying NC-based independent and freelance journalists can request authenticated, timestamped captures of web pages relevant to active

stories. Captures would be deposited into a designated SLNC Archive-It collection with associated provenance metadata (capture timestamp, source URL, requestor, request rationale) sufficient to support citation in published reporting, correction tracks, or evidentiary submission. The technical workflow follows established web archiving practice as documented in the Digital Preservation Coalition's Web-Archiving Technology Watch Report (Pennock, 2013), which describes Archive-It as the dominant subscription web-archiving service used by cultural-heritage and academic institutions, and identifies the WARC file format (ISO 28500:2009) as the international standard for archived web content (Pennock, 2013). Wong and Chiu's (2024) interviews with 13 web-archiving practitioners across libraries and archives in three continents describe the curation processes (acquisition, preservation, access provision) that this tier would implement.

Eligibility would be defined through a credentialing process modeled on existing journalist-verification systems (such as Muck Rack's) and adapted to NC's specific population: contributors to NC nonprofit news outlets, freelancers with recent published work in qualifying outlets, and operators of NC-focused civic newsletters meeting baseline editorial criteria. In Bates' (1989) berrypicking terms, this tier supports the journal-run technique (placing a single source into preservable temporal sequence) and the author search technique, where "author" may be a public official or institution whose web-facing communications are tracked over time. Implementation builds on existing SLNC Archive-It infrastructure. The marginal staffing requirement is approximately 0.25-0.5 FTE of reference librarian capacity, comparable to the staffing for existing digital reference services.

Tier 2: Verification and Web Archive Forensics Workshop Series

SLNC, in partnership with UNC Hussman's Center for Innovation and Sustainability in Local Media, would develop and deliver a quarterly hybrid workshop series on web archive forensics for working NC journalists. CISLM's existing partnership infrastructure makes this feasible: it has run an annual Local Journalism Researchers Workshop five times since 2015, partnered with the NC Local News Workshop on a statewide NC Diversity Audit, and recently piloted technology deployments at four NC newsrooms through its Local NewsBot Studio (CISLM, 2025). The proposed workshops would cover effective use of the Wayback Machine and "Save Page Now", alternative capture tools (ArchiveBox, Conifer, browser extensions), authentication and provenance documentation suitable for evidentiary use, comparative archive snapshot analysis for tracking editorial changes (the journal-run berrypicking technique applied forensically), and an introduction to alternative archives such as the Library of Congress's Web

Archiving Program, which provides a model for how a major U.S. cultural institution structures researcher access to subject-curated web archives (Library of Congress, n.d.). Workshops would use a hybrid format with in-person sessions at SLNC in Raleigh and remote attendance via the NC Cardinal consortium's partner public libraries, ensuring access for journalists in news desert counties without travel barriers. The instructional model draws from SLNC's Library Development Section, which already coordinates statewide library training, and from CISLM's existing programming for NC news entrepreneurs.. As Carlson's (2019) *Nieman Reports* profile of Storytellers Without Borders demonstrates, library-hosted journalism workshops are feasible at the public library scale and produce measurable instructional outcomes.

This tier addresses the instructional capacity component of the information need--building the skills to use capture tools effectively, authenticate captured pages, and interpret historical snapshots forensically. It serves the area-scanning and footnote-chasing berrypicking techniques by expanding journalists' ability to navigate and contextualize archival content beyond the Wayback Machine alone

Tier 3: NC Accountability Web Collection

SLNC would establish a curated Archive-It collection focused on NC public-interest web sources beyond the state-government scope of its existing program. Vlassenroot, Tao, and Mechant's (2025) review of national-library web archiving practices documents a global shift from exploratory to systematic capture strategies across institutions and the use of advanced tools such as SolrWayback for full-text and temporal search. The proposed collection would adopt these emerging practices for NC public-interest content. Scope would cover county and municipal government, school boards, public utilities, major NC institutions (hospitals, universities, public-facing corporate sources of accountability significance), and selected NC media outlets that may themselves be at risk of closure or website loss, including outlets whose blocking of the Internet Archive would otherwise create gaps in the historical record.

A submission portal would let credentialed journalists suggest URLs for inclusion, with curation decisions reviewed by SLNC staff in consultation with the State Archives. Schafer and Winters (2021) frame web archiving as inherently political; every selection decision is also a decision about whose voices are preserved, whose are not, and on what terms. Their analysis of politically charged Archive-It collections illustrates that good governance requires transparent collection development policies and meaningful community input. The proposal assumes an advisory committee--including representatives from NC nonprofit newsrooms, the State Archives, the NC Press Association, and CISLM--would

develop and oversee the collection development policy. The collection would build on SLNC's existing Archive-It capacity (State Archives of NC & State Library of NC, n.d.) and on the curatorial precedent of the Black Hills Knowledge Network model, while extending it to NC's specific accountability landscape. Where physical NC accountability materials need digitization for inclusion, SLNC could partner with the NC Digital Heritage Center, which already provides digitization, metadata, and hosting services to NC partner institutions and serves as the NC service hub for the Digital Public Library of America (NC Digital Heritage Center, n.d.; Digital Public Library of America, n.d.).

This tier addresses the institutional preservation component of the information need. In Bates's (1989) berrypicking terms, it supports area scanning across NC public-interest content and provides a curated discovery resource resistant to the publisher-blocking dynamics that have made the open Wayback Machine increasingly unreliable for accountability source preservation.

Limitations, Open Questions, and Feasibility

Several limitations and open questions warrant explicit acknowledgment. First, eligibility scoping is genuinely difficult. The line between "independent journalist" and "civic blogger" or "advocacy writer" is blurry, and any credentialing system will produce edge cases. Existing systems (Muck Rack, the National Press Club, Reporters Committee for Freedom of the Press) provide useful templates but each has its own scope problems. The proposal's working assumption is that eligibility should be relatively inclusive at the workshop tier (open to all NC residents producing public-interest reporting) and more selective at the capture-on-demand and submission tiers, where credentialing reduces both abuse and curation burden.

Second, evidentiary authentication is a complex legal-technical question. Archived web pages are routinely submitted as evidence in federal litigation (Sircar, 2026), and the technical standards for what constitutes an authenticated capture are reasonably well-developed (timestamp, hash, provenance metadata). However, SLNC is not in a position to provide legal authentication itself. The service would produce captures suitable for use as evidence under existing standards, but actual evidentiary submission would remain the responsibility of journalists and their counsel.

Third, scope creep can become a governance concern. SLNC's existing web archiving mission is statutorily scoped to state government. Extending into non-governmental public-interest sources requires careful governance, particularly around copyright, privacy, and selection criteria. The proposal assumes that an advisory committee — including representatives from NC nonprofit newsrooms, the State

Archives, the NC Press Association, and CISLM — would develop and oversee the collection development policy for the Accountability Web Collection.

Fourth, sustainability funding requires identification. Initial implementation could be supported through Library Services and Technology Act (LSTA) funding administered by SLNC itself, with potential expansion through grants from the Institute of Museum and Library Services, the Knight Foundation, or NC-focused journalism funders such as the NC Local News Workshop. Ongoing operational costs are modest relative to the existing SLNC web archiving budget; the additional Archive-It storage costs and reference-staffing time are within the range of existing program expansions.

Fifth, two questions worth raising for classmate input. Should the workshop tier be open to journalism students at NC universities (UNC Hussman, NC State, NC A&T, North Carolina Central) as well as to working journalists, on the theory that those students will become the next cohort of independent reporters? And should the Accountability Web Collection include selected social-media content from NC public officials, given the precedent of the existing State Government Web Site Archives ArchiveSocial program but the heightened privacy and copyright complexity of expanding to non-governmental social-media sources?

Conclusion

The conditions producing this proposal's urgency are unlikely to ease. News deserts in NC will continue to expand. Freelance and nonprofit-affiliated reporters will continue to bear a disproportionate share of accountability work. The Internet Archive's vulnerability to AI scraping, publisher blocking, and cyberattack will persist. The question is whether the population that depends on the Archive most, NC's independent accountability journalists, will have any institutional support waiting when the existing tool fails or is foreclosed.

As Koufogiannakis (2013) argued in her EBLIP7 keynote, evidence-based service development requires assembling multiple types of evidence (hard and soft, research and practice-derived) and recognizing that decisions to implement services are made in groups, through processes of articulation, assembly, assessment, agreement, and adaptation. The State Library of North Carolina has the infrastructure (its Archive-It program, its statewide delivery channels through NC Cardinal, its statutory mandate to serve all NC residents). It has the documented user need (a population whose primary verification tool is becoming structurally unavailable). And it has the institutional precedent (a small but growing body of library–newsroom partnership models) to take this on. Bonn, Bolick, and Cross's (2023) framing of "Access as Praxis"—the understanding that information access in democratic society is not a

passive condition but an active institutional commitment requiring adaptation as conditions change--captures what is at stake. NC has been losing local newspapers for two decades; it cannot afford to lose its forensic-archive infrastructure as well.

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